

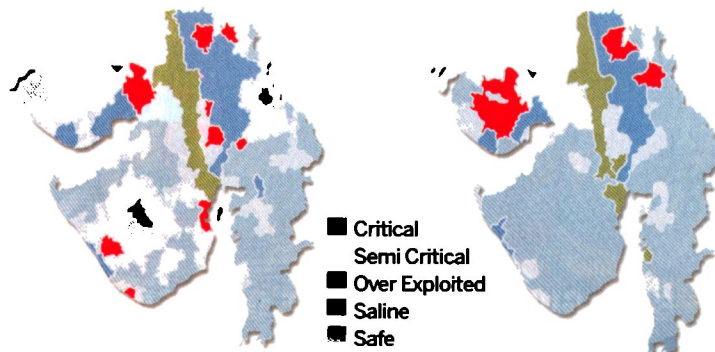


## NEW LEVELS

Sixty out of 112 dry tehsils have regained their normal water table

Groundwater situation in 2004

Groundwater situation in 2007



Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

In 2009, Gujarat registered a fantastic **9.06 PER CENT** agricultural growth rate while the nation's growth rate was less than 3 per cent.

have been built till date at a cost of Rs 181 crore. Farm ponds are built in that part of a farm where rain water collection happens in natural course.

In 2003, the Gujarat Government launched the Gujarat Green Revolution Company to propagate sprinkler and drip irrigation technology among farmers by giving them hefty incentives. Rated as the best in the country by the Union Agriculture Ministry for last three years, this initiative is one of the reasons why the groundwater level is getting recharged in the state. But it was not easy for the Government to convince the farmers, who were agitating for more power, to participate in the project. The agitating farmers were told to take to water conserving farming techniques and tapping surface water through indigenous methods which could end their dependence on power. "To get something from mother earth you have to give something back. If you don't, it will stop giving you. It can't be a one-way cycle," Modi told the farmers. The agitators understood the logic of his appeal and the rest is history.

Then there are other big irrigation schemes which have helped in enhancing the water table in Gujarat. For ex-

ample, in north and central Gujarat, the mud canal of the Sujalam Sufalam Yojana played a key role in bringing up the water level. The project targeted at pumping 'excess' water from the Kadana canal into north Gujarat dams by laying pipelines; building an unlined canal across 21 rivers in north Gujarat, and building two lakh farm-ponds. In another initiative, the state government has partnered with NGOs to build over 40 bigger-sized check dams costing up to Rs 1 crore.

Besides these long-term projects, certain short-term initiatives have also worked wonders. Last year, Gujarat had a bad monsoon but when the Government realised that rains could hit the state in the last leg of monsoon, it launched a quick water conservation drive by building *boribunds* (very small dams made by blocking small rivulets with the help of sand bags). In 20 days, over 2,50,000 *boribunds* came up as a result of a joint effort by the departments of rural development and forest management, NGOs and village committees. When the rains did come, these *boribunds* conserved a lot of water. Says Ram Kumar, CEO of the State Watershed Management Agency: "Our

resolve is to ensure that not a single drop of water is wasted." The success has not resulted in complacency in the Government which launched another innovative scheme three months ago to tap surface water on the hilly slopes of the tribal regions of south, north and east Gujarat by making terrace *talavis*—small ponds dug on hill slopes.

In 2009, Gujarat registered 9.06 per cent agricultural growth rate while the nation's growth rate was less than three per cent. The total cultivable area in Gujarat has increased by a phenomenal 15 per cent in the past 10 years. During that period, Gujarat's agro production has jumped from Rs 18,000 crore to Rs 49,000 crore. The state increased its cotton yield six-fold from 175 kg per hectare to 798 kg, more than the world average of 787 kg.

"Gujarat has set the finest example of groundwater management through indigenous and modern methods and through people's participation," says Tushaar Shah, senior fellow at the International Water Management Institute. When Jhamka and Khopala did it, the rest of Gujarat wondered why not they. It's time the rest of the country asked the same question. ■